Calibrating the Coupon Strike of an Autocallable Note under Local Volatility *

Samson Lam

December 2023

1 Introduction

Autocallable notes are popular market-linked structured products that offer enhanced coupon yields alongside conditional capital protection. These notes redeem early when the underlying reaches a predefined knock-out barrier on scheduled observation dates. This study examines at which coupon strike, if any, a worst-of autocallable note on the Nikkei 225 (NKY), the S&P 500 (SPX) and the Hang Seng Index (HSI) prices at 98% of its issue price. The note is priced by Monte Carlo simulation under a local volatility surface from the Dupire equation (Dupire, 1994), selected among six candidate surfaces, and the coupon strike is calibrated by bisection. At the contractual coupon rates, no coupon strike prices the note at 98% of its issue price, and when the two rates are treated as free, the coupon strike increases with both.

The remainder of the report is organized as follows. Section 2 sets out the note structure, and Section 3 describes the data and the volatility estimators. Section 4 fits and selects the volatility surface, and Section 5 specifies the simulation and pricing. Section 6 calibrates the coupon strike, and Section 7 concludes.[1]

2 Note Structure

The note is written on the basket of NKY, SPX and HSI. It is issued at par and runs for 2 years from a trade date of 11 November 2023 (Table 1). Throughout, k indexes the three indices, S_t^k denotes the closing level of index k at time t and S_0^k its initial level.

Note denomination, N	USD 10,000
Issue price	100% of N
Trade date	11 November 2023
Maturity date	2 years after trade date
Observation dates, t_m	every 6 months, $m = 1, \ldots, 4$
Maximum rate of interest, r_+	2% per annum
Minimum rate of interest, r_-	0.01% per annum
Knock-out barrier, B_+	1.10 (110% of initial spot)
Knock-in barrier, B_-	0.50 (50% of initial spot)

Table 1: Terms of the note.

The variable interest reference price is the relative level of the worst-performing index, $R_t = \min_k S_t^k/S_0^k$. At each observation date t_m, the note pays a coupon rate of r_+ if the reference price is at or above the coupon strike c, and r_- otherwise. The coupon strike is the parameter that the

*This is a class project for the Chinese University of Hong Kong's FINA 4150 course, completed by a group of three members.

[1]Code and replication data are available at *GitHub*.

project calibrates. A knock-out event occurs when the reference price is at or above the knock-out barrier B_+ on an observation date. In this case, the note redeems for its full denomination and expires, and the coupon for that period is still paid. A knock-in event occurs if the reference price falls to or below the knock-in barrier B_- at any time during the life of the note. At the final redemption, if no knock-in event has occurred, the note repays the full denomination, and if one has occurred, the note repays $N \cdot \min(1, R_{t_4})$.

3 Data and Volatility Estimation

Option chains for the three indices were fetched from Bloomberg as of 11 November 2023. Entries without a last price were dropped. Overnight index swap rates were quoted on a daily compounding basis. On a day-count basis β (365 for Hong Kong and Japan, 360 for the United States), the quoted rate r_{daily} is converted to a continuously compounded rate by $r = \beta \ln(1+r_{\text{daily}}/\beta)$, and the resulting rates are interpolated across maturity by a cubic spline to give $r(T)$.

3.1 At-the-money forward

Put-call parity under a continuous dividend yield q relates the call price C and the put price P at strike K and maturity T by $C(K) - P(K) = S_0 e^{-qT} - Ke^{-rT}$. Setting $C = P$ yields the at-the-money forward (ATMF) strike

$$K_{\text{ATMF}} = S_0 e^{(r-q)T}.$$

Since K_{ATMF} is not among the quoted strikes, we locate the tightest interval $[K_1, K_2]$ such that

$$C(K_1) > P(K_1) \quad \text{and} \quad C(K_2) < P(K_2),$$

which brackets K_{ATMF}. We then approximate the first derivatives at K_1 by finite differences,

$$\begin{aligned}
\frac{C(K_{\text{ATMF}}) - C(K_1)}{K_{\text{ATMF}} - K_1} &\approx \left.\frac{\partial C}{\partial K}\right|_{K_1} \approx -e^{-rT}\Phi(d_2)\big|_{K_1}, \\
\frac{P(K_{\text{ATMF}}) - P(K_1)}{K_{\text{ATMF}} - K_1} &\approx \left.\frac{\partial P}{\partial K}\right|_{K_1} \approx \quad e^{-rT}\Phi(-d_2)\big|_{K_1}, \\
\frac{C(K_{\text{ATMF}}) - C(K_1)}{K_{\text{ATMF}} - K_1} &\approx \left.\frac{\partial C}{\partial K}\right|_{K_1} \approx \frac{C(K_2) - C(K_1)}{K_2 - K_1},
\end{aligned}$$

where Φ is the standard normal distribution function, σ_{BS} the Black–Scholes implied volatility and $d_2 = [\ln(S_0/K) + (r - q - \sigma_{\text{BS}}^2/2)T]/(\sigma_{\text{BS}}\sqrt{T})$. Near the forward, $\Phi(-d_2) \approx \Phi(d_2) \approx \frac{1}{2}$, so the two derivatives are approximately equal and opposite. Therefore, $C(K_{\text{ATMF}}) = P(K_{\text{ATMF}})$ implies

$$C(K_{\text{ATMF}}) \approx \frac{C(K_1) + P(K_1)}{2},$$

$$K_{\text{ATMF}} \approx \frac{C(K_{\text{ATMF}}) - C(K_1)}{C(K_2) - C(K_1)} (K_2 - K_1) + K_1. \tag{1}$$

3.2 Implied volatility and dividend yield

The implied variance σ^2_{BS} is recovered from the out-of-the-money quote at each strike by bisection on the Black–Scholes price, described in Appendix A. The implied dividend yield q follows from the forward strike relation under a non-negativity floor,

$$q \approx \max\left(0,\; r - \frac{\ln(K_{\mathrm{ATMF}}/S_0)}{T}\right),$$

which is interpolated across maturity by a cubic spline to give $q(T)$.

3.3 Local volatility

In terms of the undiscounted price $C(K,T)$ of a call on the driftless forward, the local variance follows from the Dupire equation (Dupire, 1994),

$$\sigma^2_{\mathrm{loc}}(K,T) = \frac{\partial C/\partial T}{\frac{1}{2}K^2\,\partial^2 C/\partial K^2}, \tag{2}$$

derived in Appendix C, with both derivatives taken by three-point central differences on the Black–Scholes price in the forward, using a step of 1 day in maturity and 1% of the strike spacing in strike.

3.4 Gatheral's mapping

As a third route, the fitted implied surface is mapped to local variance by the formula of Gatheral (2002). In terms of the log forward moneyness $y = \ln(K/K_{\mathrm{ATMF}})$ and the total implied variance $w = \sigma^2_{\mathrm{BS}}T$, the Dupire equation becomes the relation derived in Appendix D,

$$\sigma^2_{\mathrm{loc}} = \frac{\partial w/\partial T}{1 - \dfrac{y}{w}\dfrac{\partial w}{\partial y} + \dfrac{1}{4}\left(-\dfrac{1}{4} - \dfrac{1}{w} + \dfrac{y^2}{w^2}\right)\left(\dfrac{\partial w}{\partial y}\right)^2 + \dfrac{1}{2}\dfrac{\partial^2 w}{\partial y^2}}. \tag{3}$$

4 Volatility Surface

4.1 Fitting the surface

At each maturity, the implied and the local variance are each fitted across log forward moneyness y by

$$\sigma^2(y) = \sigma^2_{\mathrm{ATMF}} + \delta\,\frac{\tanh(\kappa y)}{\kappa} + \frac{\gamma}{2}\left(\frac{\tanh(\kappa y)}{\kappa}\right)^2, \tag{4}$$

where σ^2 stands for either variance, δ is the skew, γ the convexity and κ the celerity.

Curves that are concave are dropped since a concave curve inverts the smile and destabilizes the interpolation across maturity that follows. This removes two implied and five local curves for HSI and one implied and seven local curves for SPX, and none for NKY. The fitted curves are shown in Appendix F.

A continuous surface is obtained by interpolating the fitted curves across maturity, either linearly or by a cubic spline. Linear interpolation joins adjacent maturities by a straight line, so that a positive variance at every knot guarantees a positive variance between them. The cubic spline of Appendix B produces a smoother surface, fitting a piecewise cubic whose first and second derivatives are continuous at every knot.

4.2 Selecting the surface

Surface	NKY	HSI	SPX
Implied, cubic	0.0	0.0	10.4
Implied, linear	0.0	0.0	0.0
Dupire, cubic	0.0	12.5	10.6
Dupire, linear	0.0	0.2	0.0
Gatheral, cubic	15.7	14.0	33.6
Gatheral, linear	11.7	10.5	16.1

Table 2: Percentage of the moneyness window on which the fitted variance is negative.

The implied, the Dupire and the Gatheral variance under the two interpolations yield six candidate surfaces, plotted in Appendix F. In the percentage of the moneyness window on which the fitted variance is negative (Table 2), linear interpolation is never worse than cubic and is strictly better in six of the nine pairs. Gatheral's mapping is the weakest of the three, leaving between 10.5% and 33.6% of the window with a negative variance, which we attribute to the mapping being applied to an already fitted implied surface rather than to the data, so that estimation error from the first fit propagates into the second. The simulation employs the Dupire local variance under linear interpolation, the local variance surface with the smallest negative share (at most 0.2%), shown in Figure 1.

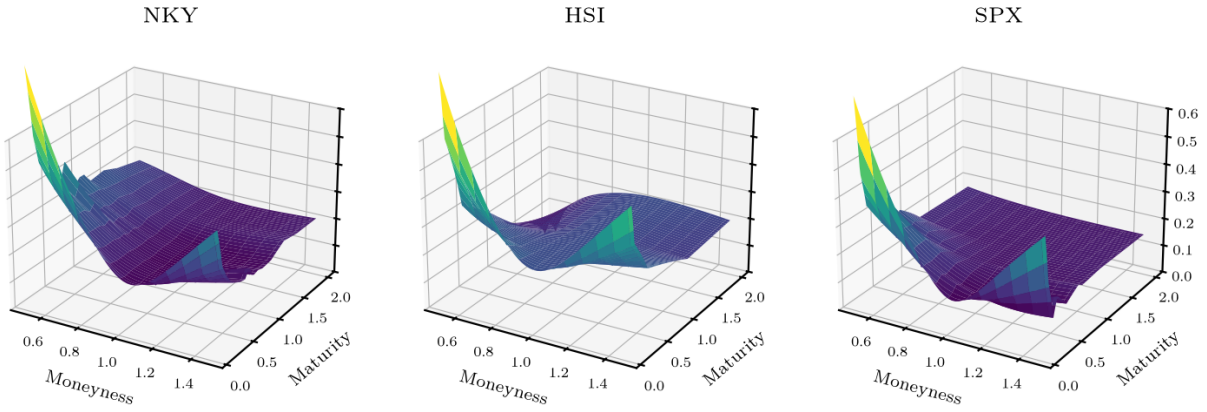


Figure 1: The selected surface, Dupire local volatility interpolated linearly across maturity. The vertical axis is volatility.

5 Monte Carlo Simulation

The correlation matrix of SPX, HSI and NKY is computed from the latest 10 years of historical returns. The Cholesky factor of this matrix maps independent standard normal draws to the correlated standard normal variables Z_j^k, the standardized increments over step j of the Brownian motions W^k that drive the indices. Under the local volatility model, each index follows $dS_t^k/S_t^k = f\,dt + \sigma_{\mathrm{loc},k}\,dW_t^k$, where f is the forward rate applying over the step. Applying Itô's lemma to $\ln S_t^k$

and freezing $\sigma_{\mathrm{loc},k}$ over each step yields the log-Euler scheme

$$S^k_{t_{j+1}} = S^k_{t_j} \exp\left[\left(\frac{t_{j+1}\, r(t_{j+1}) - t_j\, r(t_j)}{t_{j+1} - t_j} - \tfrac{1}{2}\sigma^2_{k,j}\right)(t_{j+1} - t_j) + \sigma_{k,j}\sqrt{t_{j+1} - t_j}\, Z^k_j\right], \tag{5}$$

where

$$\sigma^2_{k,j} = \sigma^2_{\mathrm{loc},k}\left(\ln \frac{S^k_{t_j}}{F^k_{t_j}},\, t_j\right), \qquad F^k_T = S^k_0 \exp\{(r(T) - q^k(T))T\}.$$

Where the interpolated $\sigma^2_{k,j}$ is negative, it is replaced by the smallest non-negative value seen so far in the simulation.

5.1 Autocallable pricing

Write $\Pi_m = \prod_{l<m} \mathbf{1}\{R_{t_l} < B_+\}$ for the indicator that no knock-out event has occurred before t_m, and $D_m = e^{-r(t_m)t_m}$ for the discount factor. The Monte Carlo estimate of the note value at coupon strike c is the average over the M simulated paths (Appendix E) of the sum of three components,

$$V(c) = \frac{1}{M}\sum_{i=1}^{M}(I_i + O_i + G_i)\,. \tag{6}$$

The variable interest accrues at each observation date and stops once the note has knocked out,

$$I = N\sum_{m=1}^{4}\left(\frac{r_+}{2}\,\mathbf{1}\{R_{t_m} \geq c\} + \frac{r_-}{2}\,\mathbf{1}\{R_{t_m} < c\}\right)\Pi_m D_m.$$

The knock-out redemption pays the denomination at the first observation date at which the knock-out barrier is reached, at $\tau = \min\{t_m : R_{t_m} \geq B_+\}$,

$$O = N\,\mathbf{1}\{\tau < \infty\}\, e^{-r(\tau)\tau}.$$

The final redemption applies only to paths that never knocked out, and is reduced by the terminal reference price only if the knock-in barrier was breached at some point,

$$G = N\,\mathbf{1}\{\tau = \infty\}\,(\mathbf{1}\{\min_t R_t \leq B_-\}\min(1, R_{t_4}) + \mathbf{1}\{\min_t R_t > B_-\})\,D_4.$$

6 Coupon Strike Calibration

We calibrate the coupon strike at which the note prices at 98% of its issue price by the bisection algorithm of Appendix A, which terminates when $|V(c) - 0.98N| \leq$ USD 0.1, and returns no result if the algorithm exhausts 100 iterations.

At the contractual rates of $r_+ = 2\%$ and $r_- = 0.01\%$ the search returns no result. We attribute the failure to the level of interest rates. The 2-year USD rate was 4.83%, so a coupon of 2% falls well below the rate at which the note is discounted. Since the contractual rates admit no solution, we treat the two rates as free and identify the pairs that do. Over the grid of r_+ and r_- in Table 3, a solution first exists at $r_+ = 5.86\%$, and the coupon strike increases with both rates, since a higher coupon raises the note value and a higher strike is needed to restore the target price.

Maximum	Minimum rate of interest r_-, %														
rate r_+, %	0.010	0.081	0.151	0.222	0.293	0.364	0.434	0.505	0.576	0.646	0.717	0.788	0.859	0.929	1.000
2.00	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–
3.29	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–
4.57	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–
5.86	0.702	0.703	0.704	0.706	0.707	0.708	0.709	0.711	0.712	0.713	0.715	0.716	0.718	0.719	0.720
7.14	0.798	0.799	0.800	0.802	0.803	0.804	0.805	0.807	0.809	0.810	0.812	0.813	0.815	0.816	0.818
8.43	0.846	0.847	0.849	0.850	0.851	0.853	0.854	0.856	0.857	0.859	0.861	0.862	0.864	0.865	0.867
9.71	0.878	0.879	0.880	0.882	0.883	0.884	0.886	0.887	0.889	0.890	0.892	0.893	0.895	0.896	0.898
11.00	0.901	0.902	0.903	0.905	0.906	0.907	0.909	0.910	0.911	0.913	0.914	0.915	0.917	0.918	0.920
12.29	0.918	0.920	0.921	0.922	0.923	0.925	0.926	0.927	0.929	0.930	0.931	0.933	0.934	0.936	0.937
13.57	0.933	0.934	0.935	0.937	0.938	0.939	0.940	0.941	0.943	0.944	0.946	0.947	0.948	0.950	0.952
14.86	0.945	0.946	0.948	0.949	0.950	0.951	0.953	0.954	0.955	0.956	0.958	0.959	0.961	0.962	0.964
16.14	0.956	0.957	0.958	0.959	0.961	0.962	0.963	0.965	0.966	0.967	0.969	0.970	0.971	0.972	0.974
17.43	0.965	0.966	0.968	0.969	0.970	0.971	0.972	0.973	0.975	0.976	0.977	0.979	0.980	0.981	0.983
18.71	0.973	0.974	0.976	0.977	0.978	0.979	0.980	0.981	0.983	0.984	0.985	0.986	0.988	0.989	0.991
20.00	0.981	0.982	0.983	0.984	0.985	0.986	0.987	0.989	0.990	0.991	0.993	0.994	0.995	0.997	0.998

Table 3: Coupon strike that prices the note at 98% of its issue price. A dash marks a pair of coupon rates for which the search returns no result.

7 Conclusion

This study examined at which coupon strike, if any, a worst-of autocallable note on NKY, SPX and HSI prices at 98% of its issue price. We fitted implied and local volatility surfaces to the three indices, and of the four local variance surfaces, the Dupire local variance interpolated linearly across maturity left the smallest part of the moneyness window with negative variance. Under this surface, we simulated the three indices jointly and valued the note, whose coupon, knock-out and knock-in all reference the worst-performing index. At the contractual coupon rates of 2% and 0.01%, no coupon strike prices the note at 98% of its issue price, because a coupon well below the discount rate leaves the note worth less than the target at any strike. When the two rates are treated as free, the coupon strike increases with both.

A limitation is that the surface is fitted to the last traded option prices from Bloomberg. The last trade can fall well before the snapshot, so the option price, the time to maturity and the spot price are not contemporaneous, which introduces noise into the surface fit. Future work could fit the surface to synchronous bid-ask mid quotes.

References

Dupire, B., Pricing with a smile. *Risk*, 1994, **7**, 18–20.

Gatheral, J., Lecture 1: Stochastic volatility and local volatility. Case Studies in Financial Modelling Course Notes, Courant Institute of Mathematical Sciences, Fall Term 2002.

A Bisection

For f continuous on $[a,b]$ with $f(a)<0<f(b)$, a root $x^*\in(a,b)$ exists by the intermediate value theorem. Set $x_l=(a_l+b_l)/2$. If $|f(x_l)|<\varepsilon$ stop, otherwise replace $b_{l+1}=x_l$ when $f(x_l)>0$ and $a_{l+1}=x_l$ when $f(x_l)<0$, and stop when $|b_l-a_l|<\eta$. The bracket halves at each step, so $b_l-a_l=2^{-l}(b-a)$ and $|x_l-x^*|\le 2^{-(l+1)}(b-a)$, so the convergence is linear with rate one half.

B Cubic spline

On knots $x_0<\cdots<x_n$ with values f_k, write s_k for the cubic on $[x_k,x_{k+1}]$, $m_k=s''(x_k)$ and $h_k=x_{k+1}-x_k$. Requiring continuity of s, s' and s'' at the interior knots yields

$$h_{k-1}m_{k-1}+2(h_{k-1}+h_k)m_k+h_km_{k+1}=6\left(\frac{f_{k+1}-f_k}{h_k}-\frac{f_k-f_{k-1}}{h_{k-1}}\right),$$

for $k=1,\dots,n-1$. The implementation closes the system by the not-a-knot conditions, which require s''' to be continuous at x_1 and x_{n-1},

$$\frac{m_1-m_0}{h_0}=\frac{m_2-m_1}{h_1},\qquad \frac{m_{n-1}-m_{n-2}}{h_{n-2}}=\frac{m_n-m_{n-1}}{h_{n-1}}.$$

Together with the $n-1$ interior equations, these two conditions determine $\{m_k\}$ uniquely, and the coefficients of s_k follow from m_k and f_k.

C The Dupire equation

The forward price follows the driftless diffusion $dF_t=\sigma_{\mathrm{loc}}(F_t,t)F_t\,dW_t$. Write $\varphi(F,T)$ for the density of F_T. The undiscounted call is

$$C(K,T)=\int_K^\infty (F-K)\,\varphi(F,T)\,dF,$$

$$\frac{\partial C}{\partial K}=-\int_K^\infty \varphi\,dF,\qquad \frac{\partial^2 C}{\partial K^2}=\varphi(K,T).$$

The density satisfies the Fokker–Planck equation $\partial_T\varphi=\frac12\partial_F^2(\sigma_{\mathrm{loc}}^2F^2\varphi)$. Therefore,

$$\frac{\partial C}{\partial T}=\int_K^\infty (F-K)\,\partial_T\varphi\,dF=\frac12\int_K^\infty (F-K)\,\partial_F^2\big(\sigma_{\mathrm{loc}}^2F^2\varphi\big)\,dF.$$

Integrating by parts twice,

$$\frac{\partial C}{\partial T}=\frac12\,\sigma_{\mathrm{loc}}^2(K,T)\,K^2\,\varphi(K,T)=\frac12\,\sigma_{\mathrm{loc}}^2(K,T)\,K^2\,\frac{\partial^2 C}{\partial K^2},$$

which rearranges to the equation of Section 3.3.

D Gatheral's mapping

For $w = \sigma_{\mathrm{BS}}^2 T$, write $C(y,T) = C_{\mathrm{BS}}(y, w(y,T))$ for the market price, which depends on maturity only through w. In terms of y, the Dupire equation of Appendix C becomes

$$\frac{\partial C}{\partial T} = \frac{\sigma_{\mathrm{loc}}^2}{2}\left(\frac{\partial^2 C}{\partial y^2} - \frac{\partial C}{\partial y}\right).$$

The Black–Scholes price in w satisfies the identities of Gatheral (2002),

$$\frac{\partial^2 C_{\mathrm{BS}}}{\partial w^2} = \left(-\frac{1}{8} - \frac{1}{2w} + \frac{y^2}{2w^2}\right)\frac{\partial C_{\mathrm{BS}}}{\partial w}, \qquad \frac{\partial^2 C_{\mathrm{BS}}}{\partial y \partial w} = \left(\frac{1}{2} - \frac{y}{w}\right)\frac{\partial C_{\mathrm{BS}}}{\partial w},$$

$$\frac{\partial^2 C_{\mathrm{BS}}}{\partial y^2} - \frac{\partial C_{\mathrm{BS}}}{\partial y} = 2\,\frac{\partial C_{\mathrm{BS}}}{\partial w}.$$

The chain rule through $w(y,T)$ yields

$$\frac{\partial C}{\partial T} = \frac{\partial C_{\mathrm{BS}}}{\partial w}\frac{\partial w}{\partial T}, \qquad \frac{\partial C}{\partial y} = \frac{\partial C_{\mathrm{BS}}}{\partial y} + \frac{\partial C_{\mathrm{BS}}}{\partial w}\frac{\partial w}{\partial y},$$
$$\frac{\partial^2 C}{\partial y^2} = \frac{\partial^2 C_{\mathrm{BS}}}{\partial y^2} + 2\frac{\partial^2 C_{\mathrm{BS}}}{\partial y \partial w}\frac{\partial w}{\partial y} + \frac{\partial^2 C_{\mathrm{BS}}}{\partial w^2}\left(\frac{\partial w}{\partial y}\right)^2 + \frac{\partial C_{\mathrm{BS}}}{\partial w}\frac{\partial^2 w}{\partial y^2}.$$

Therefore,

$$\frac{\partial^2 C}{\partial y^2} - \frac{\partial C}{\partial y} = \frac{\partial C_{\mathrm{BS}}}{\partial w}\left[2 - \frac{2y}{w}\frac{\partial w}{\partial y} + \left(-\frac{1}{8} - \frac{1}{2w} + \frac{y^2}{2w^2}\right)\left(\frac{\partial w}{\partial y}\right)^2 + \frac{\partial^2 w}{\partial y^2}\right].$$

Substituting this and $\partial C/\partial T$ into the Dupire equation yields

$$\frac{\partial w}{\partial T} = \sigma_{\mathrm{loc}}^2\left[1 - \frac{y}{w}\frac{\partial w}{\partial y} + \frac{1}{4}\left(-\frac{1}{4} - \frac{1}{w} + \frac{y^2}{w^2}\right)\left(\frac{\partial w}{\partial y}\right)^2 + \frac{1}{2}\frac{\partial^2 w}{\partial y^2}\right].$$

Solving for σ_{loc}^2 yields the mapping of Section 3.4.

E Simulation algorithm

Given M paths and J steps, for each path:

1. Evolve the three indices by the recursion of Section 5 and form the reference price R_t at every step.
2. Record the knock-in indicator from the running minimum of R_t over all steps, not only the observation dates.
3. At each observation date t_m, accrue the interest of Section 5.1 if the note is still alive, and record a knock-out at the first date with $R_{t_m} \geq B_+$.
4. Discount each component at its own payment date rather than at maturity, since the knock-out redemption and the coupons are paid when they occur.

Averaging over paths yields $V(c)$, and the coupon strike is the value at which $V(c)$ reaches the target.

F Fitted volatility curves and surfaces

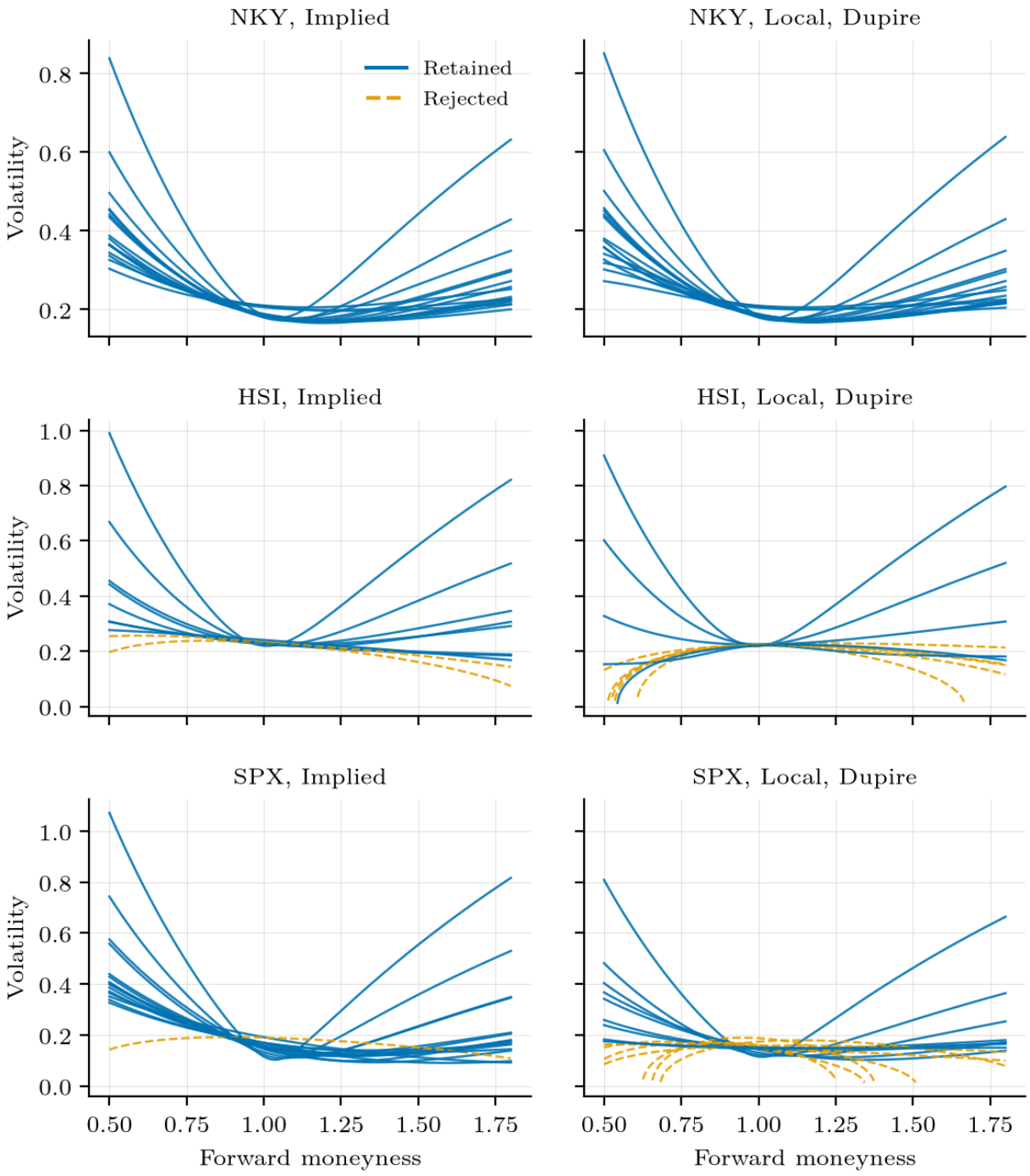


Figure 2: Fitted implied and local volatility curves across forward moneyness.

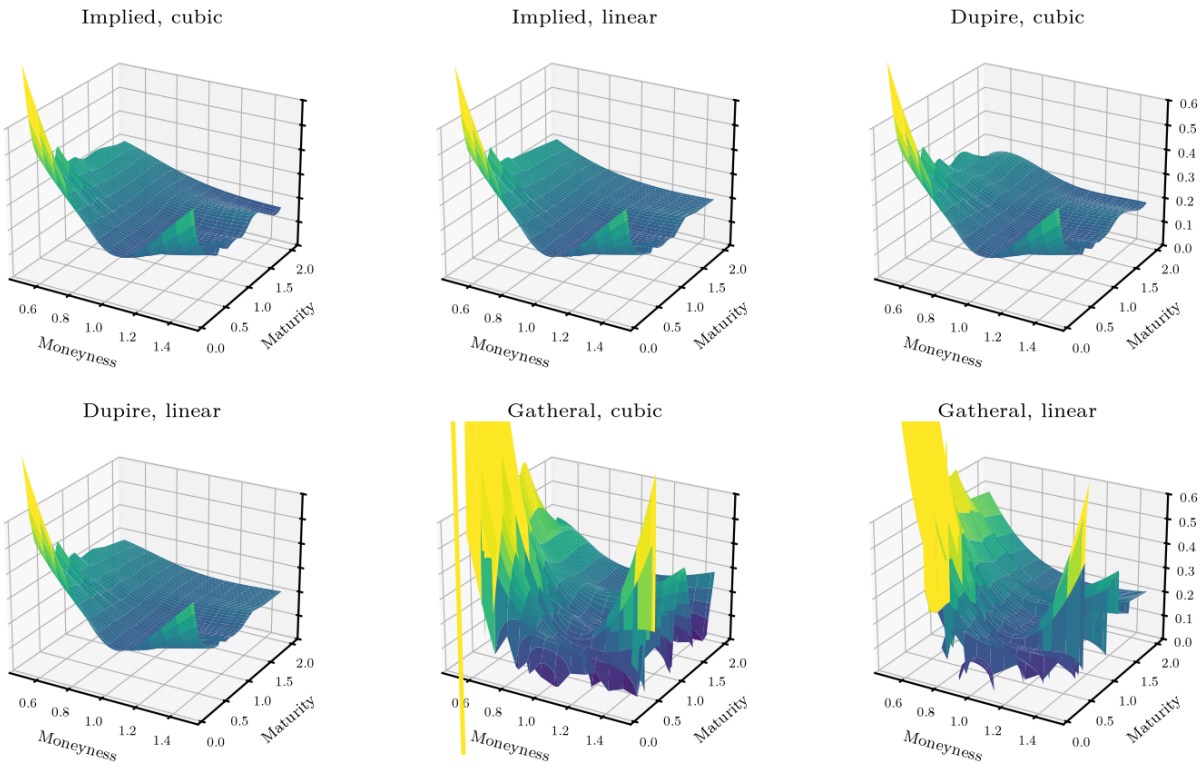


Figure 3: NKY fitted surfaces; blank regions mark negative fitted variance.

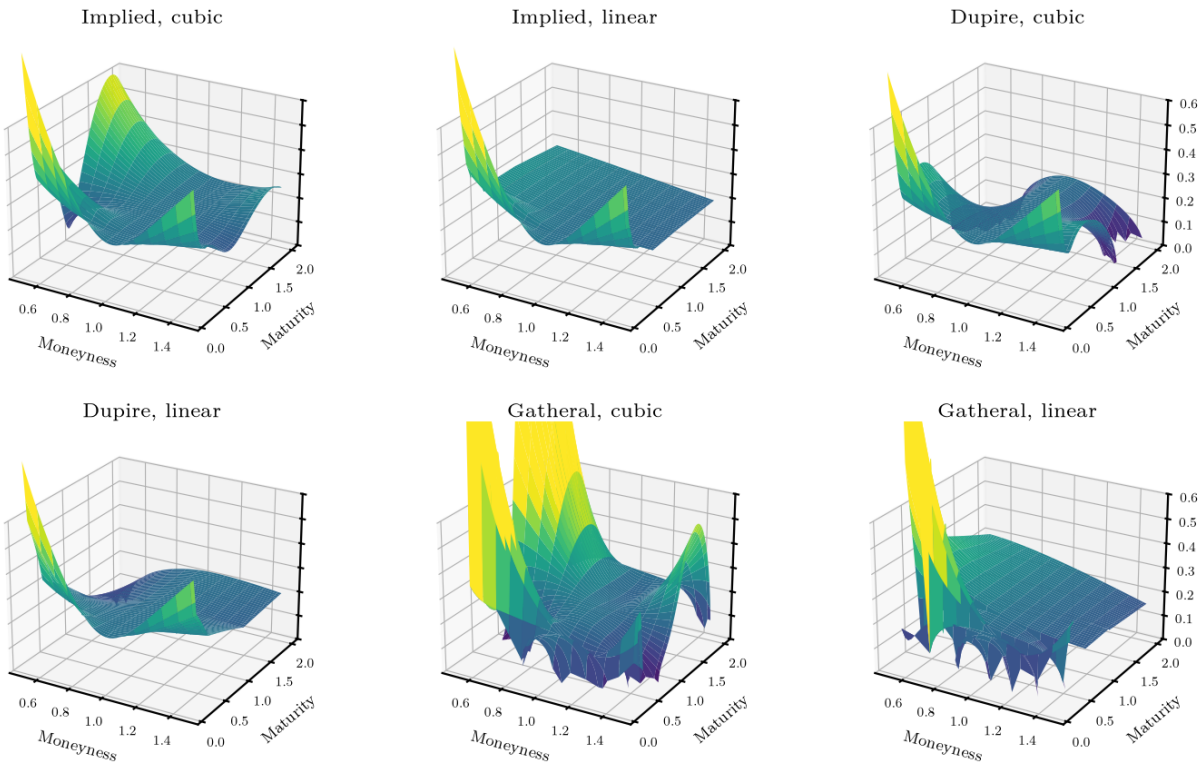


Figure 4: HSI fitted surfaces; blank regions mark negative fitted variance.

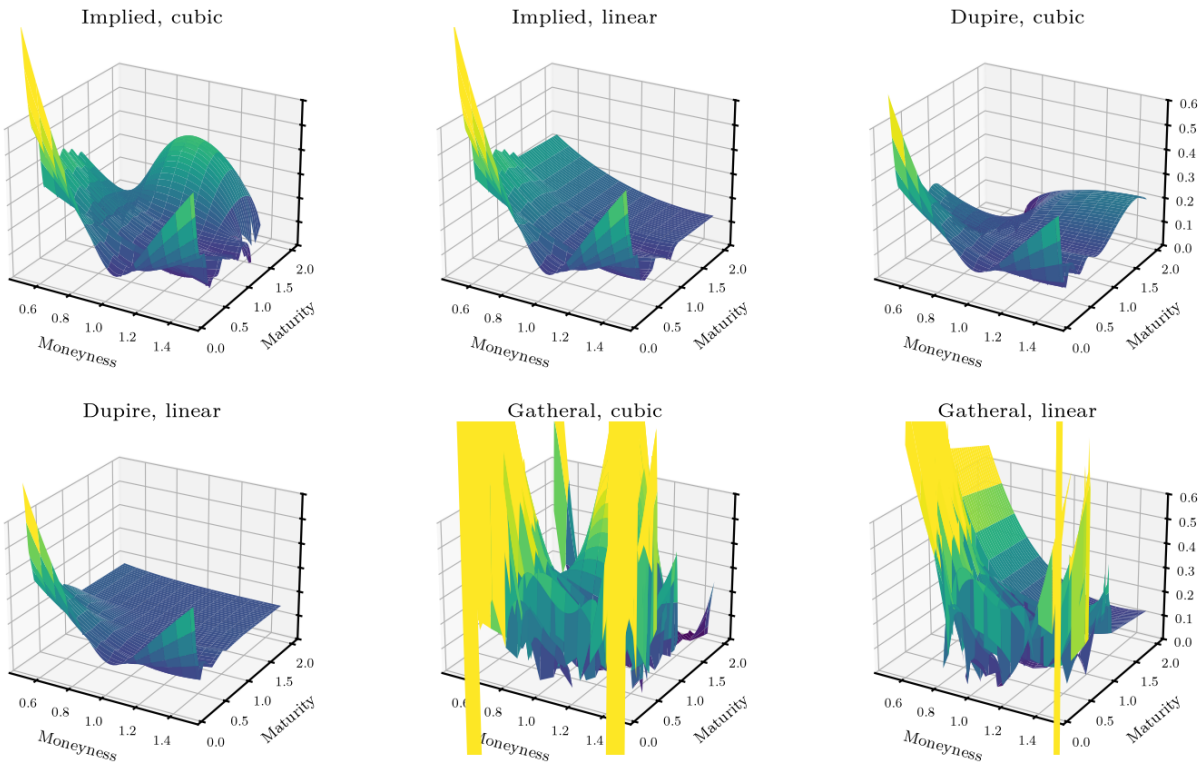


Figure 5: SPX fitted surfaces; blank regions mark negative fitted variance.